



# Lyall's Wren Journal

## Ecosystem perturbations

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## Contents

|     |                                                      |   |
|-----|------------------------------------------------------|---|
| 1   | Some definitions                                     | 1 |
| 1.1 | Ecosystem . . . . .                                  | 1 |
| 1.2 | Perturbation . . . . .                               | 1 |
| 2   | Types of perturbations                               | 2 |
| 3   | Perturbations, public perception and ecology reality | 3 |

## 1 Some definitions

For the futur explanation, i'll need to define the terms i'll use.

### 1.1 Ecosystem

An **ecosystem** (or ecological system) consists of all the organisms and the abiotic pools (or physical environment) with which they interact (Tansley 2016). It's all the living organisms (biocenosis) in an environment (biotope), with all the interactions between eachovers and with the environment. This include therefore the energy flux between the organisms, the life cycle with the decomposition phase and the perturbations and resilience, whichis the main topic of this article.

Another very important of the ecosystem is it dynamic aspect. All the interactions are regulated in a certain way where the ecosystem stay generally stable. This introduct the concepts of perturbations (that alter that balance), resistance (face to perturbations) and resilience (after a perturbations) (Folke et al. 2004) (Grimm and Wissel 1997).

The ecocystem also lead to the concept of ecotope, the smallest ecosystem unit (Margulis and Fester 1991). See that this definition doesn't give a scale, in fact, a human can be considered as an ecosystem where the human is the environment and all the bacteria and microorganismes in it, are the organisms in interaction. This introduct the concept of meta-organisms also knowed as holobiont (Baedke, Fábregas-Tejeda, and Nieves Delgado 2020) (Tansley 2016), but this is a complete other subject.

### 1.2 Perturbation

In english, the disturbance designate the cause of a perturbation, which is the consequence.

A **disturbance** is "a cause; a physical force, agent, or process, either abiotic or biotic, causing a perturbation (which includes stress) in an ecological component or system; relative to a specified reference state and system; defined by specific characteristics".

A **perturbation** is "an effect; the response of an ecological component or system to disturbance or other ecological process as indicated by deviations in the values describing the properties of the

component or system; relative to a specified reference condition; characterized by direction, magnitude, and persistence". This can be temporary (back to previous state) or permanent (no return to previous state).

A **stress** is "an effect; a physiological or functional effect; the physiological response of an individual, or the functional response of a system caused by disturbance or other ecological process; relative to a specified reference condition; characterized by direction, magnitude, and persistence; a type of perturbation". (Rykiel 1985)

This definition of perturbation talk about a change, which necessite the comparaisn to a previous state in the studied ecosystem. This state is usually the climax of the ecosystem (the state where mainly the biomass is maximal, the ratio productivity/biomass is the highest, maximum specific diversity).

There is also more characterisation of a perturbation than "direction, magnitude and persistance", such as size, duration, resistance and resilience. Let's define those terms too.

The **size** is simply the surface of the ecosystem impacted. It can be mesured as a value (squared kilometers), or a ratio of the ecosystem surface.

The **duration** is the time from the disturbance to the next ecosystem climax (previous or new one).

The **intensity** is the physic force of the disturbance by surface unit and time.

The **severity** is the impact of the disturbance on organisms. (Chauchard 2025)

The **resistance** is the capacity to remain unchanged face to a disturbance (Grimm and Wissel 1997).

The **resilience** is "the capacity of a system to absorb disturbance and reorganize while under-going change so as to still retain essentially the same function, structure, identity, and feedbacks" (Walker et al. 2004).

The **persistance** is the capacity to respond face to a perturbation disturbance, to reach back the climax (previous or new one) (Holling 1973).

The **net change** is the difference between the climax before and after the disturbance.

Disturbances not happend only one time, so we can create a disturbance regimes concept. A **disturbance regimes** is the evolution and characterisation of disturbances in time. This is caracterised with occurrence, return interval, spatiale organisation and specificity.

The **occurrence** is the number of distrbances in a given time and a given place.

The **return interval** is the duration between two disturbances.

The **spatial organisation** is the size est spacing of the disturbances.

The **specificity** is the selection of the agent between one or different habitats, species... (Chauchard 2025)

## 2 Types of perturbations

The disturbances can regroupes in 3 main types.

- The **press** is a disturbance constantly increasing in strenght along time. we can cite for instance the urbanization.
- The **pulse** is basically disturbance in a gauss form. There is a huge disturbance very for a relatively short time. For instance wildfires.
- The **ramp** is a progression agravation until it reaches a break point. For instence droughts.

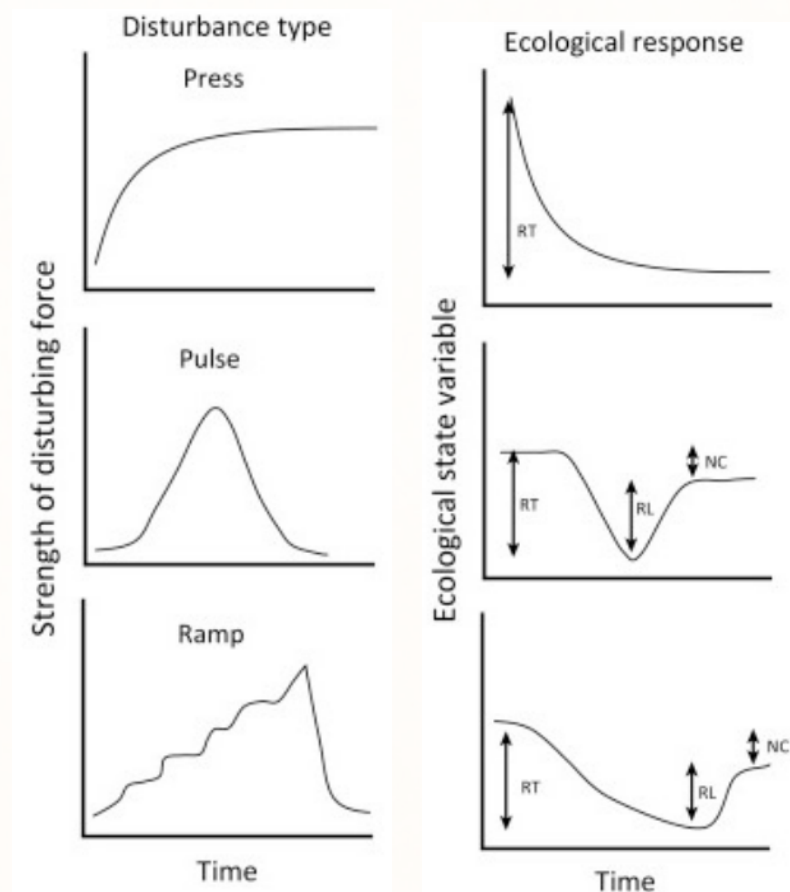


Figure 1: Disturbance types (Nimmo et al. 2015)  
RT: resistance, RL: resilience and NC: net change

Note that these are models that exist in order to simplify, classify and explain disturbances. The reality is much more complex.

We can also categorize them in anthropic and non anthropic perturbations (anthropic is human induced). This can be useful to study the impact of the human species on the ecosystems.

### 3 Perturbations, public perception and ecology reality

Perturbations are often perceived as nefarious events. This is not false but this is not true either, as always the reality is way more complex. Some ecosystems are dependent on some perturbations, and this for different reasons. One species can be specifically adapted to this ecosystem where the perturbation occurs and need it to persist, or the perturbation allows a slightly different fauna to develop by killing the predominant species (same dynamic that we see with keystone species) (this will be sourced in the future articles for each perturbation).

If I take the example of forest fire, it undeniably destroys plants, some habitats, kills some individuals. But the fire allows some different plants to grow after the perturbation for various reasons such as heat resistance, heat affinity, or just place to grow. The forest fire then allows a new ecosystem to exist with its own flora, fauna, interaction and regulation.

However, the anthropic perturbations are nefarious, for instance global warming, urbanisation, deforestation, which are also press types and aren't reversible. This led to the theorization of an Anthropocene, a geological era fundamentally altered by humans. (Lewis and Maslin 2015)(Dirzo et al. 2014)

This article is an introduction to the future articles, that will be centred on a dynamics of perturbation, and the flora and fauna adapted to it.

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